

BOYS BASKETBALL REGIONAL SEMIFINALS

Firestone's Mitchell steps up in win over Glenville

BOB MIGRA
Plain Dealer Reporter

Firestone boys basketball coach Jerry Laria called it "winning time." And when it's winning time, the Falcons want the ball in the hands of junior guard Ramel Mitchell.

Mitchell scored 13 consecutive points in the fourth quarter to lead the Falcons to a come-from-behind 48-45 victory over Glenville in the Division I regional

FIRESTONE 48
GLENVILLE 45
semifinals at the University of Akron's Rhodes Arena Thursday night.

Mitchell finished with 24 points as the Falcons improved to 19-5 and advanced to Saturday's championship against Canton GlenOak (22-3).

"Ramel stepped up there," Laria said. "That's what winning players do. He wants to win. And it's not just with his offense. He

took that No. 2, their best player [Kendall Holt] and shut him down."

Kendall Holt finished with four points, but the Tarblooders more than made up for his off night. Glenville stormed back from an atrocious first quarter to lead by five, 37-32, with seven minutes left in the fourth quarter.

A driving layup by Holt capped a 10-0 run and gave Glenville its biggest lead. Joe Pope and Jacob

Pope each made one of two foul shots for Firestone before Mitchell took over. His 3-pointer, with 3:24 left, regained the lead for Firestone, 39-37. Mitchell continued with a fast-break layup, a foul-line jump shot, and four foul shots to push the lead to 45-40, with 21 seconds left.

"In that fourth quarter, coach [Laria] just told us to come out with heart," Mitchell said. "We just said we were the better team and we wanted to prove it."

Jermale Hines scored off an of-

fensive rebound for Glenville to cut the deficit to 47-45, with eight seconds left. Joe Pope again split two foul shots, and Hines' three-quarter-court attempt to tie at the buzzer went off the backboard.

Hines led Glenville with 19 points off the bench. The Tarblooders finished 17-8.

"[Mitchell] really hurt us at the end and you couldn't foul him because he was such a good free-throw shooter," Hines said.

Firestone had its biggest lead,

14-3, on a Mitchell layup in the first quarter. The Tarblooders committed 10 turnovers in the quarter and two players — Daniel Mims and Stefone Black — picked up three quick fouls.

"We underestimated those guys a little," Hines said. "They came out running and we didn't. You couldn't see in film how fast those guys were."

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BOYS DIVISION II REGIONAL SEMIFINAL

With Wright play, Bengals move on

TIM WARSINSKEY
Plain Dealer Reporter

CANTON — While six other players packed the line and reached for the basketball, Benedictine guard Cameron Wright stood and watched a few feet away, to the left of the basket. The ball squirted out and bounced in his direction.

Suddenly, the season was in the hands of a soft-spoken freshman.

Wright never hesitated. He drove to the hoop and banked it in, giving the Bengals a 52-51 victory over Fairless in a Division II regional semifinal Thursday in the Canton Civic Center.

"Lucky, I got it and I had to go up strong with it," the 6-3 Woods said.

Asked how it felt, he responded quietly, "Blessed."

The Bengals (15-10) are counting their blessings going into Saturday's 3 p.m. regional final against Poland Seminary (22-3). Benedictine was 10-10 against a strenuous schedule, and now finds itself one game from the state semifinals.

"We've had our ups and downs," Wright said. "We believe we can accomplish anything."

"Fearless" Fairless (16-9), winner of five overtime games this season, rallied from a 10-point deficit in the third quarter and led, 48-43, with five minutes left in the game. With Fairless leading, 49-48, Benedictine decided

to dribble away the final four minutes and play for the last shot, but a steal by Falcons guard Jonah Manack led to Lucas Erb's basket for a 51-48 advantage with 1 minute left.

Wright scored on a tip-in with 15 seconds remaining, and the Bengals were down, 51-50.

In a rare ball-handling miscue, a Fairless inbound pass bounced off a Falcon out of bounds, giving the ball to Benedictine under its basket. Senior guard Aaron Horn lobbed the pass to 6-6 senior Branden Woods, but he lost the ball in a crush of bodies and it headed toward Wright.

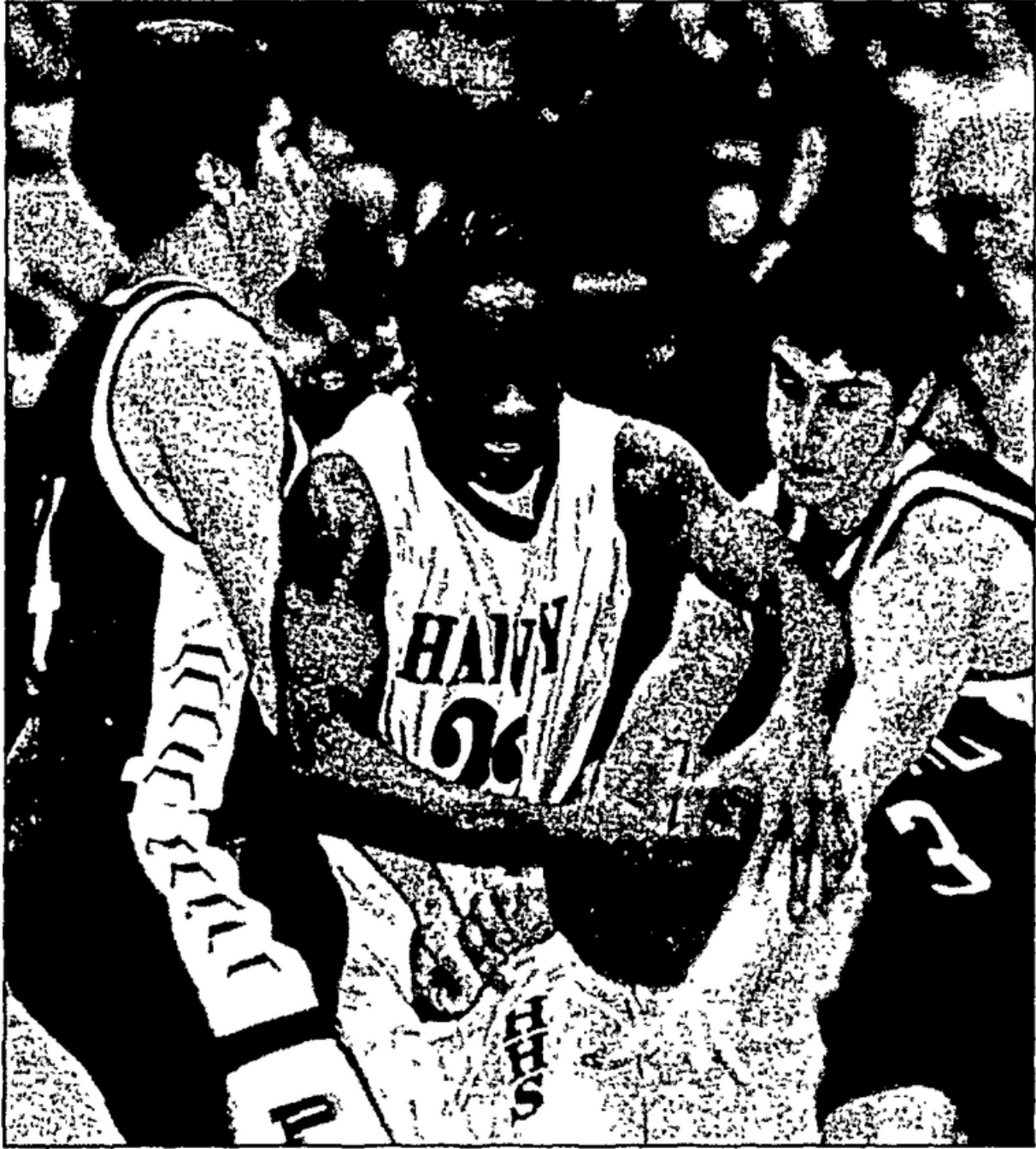
Woods led Benedictine with 16 points and Wright scored 12. Freshman Derek Jackson had seven points, including a 50-footer at the halftime buzzer.

Poland Seminary 42, Harvey 41 Bulldogs senior guard Chris Lovell's 3-pointer with 54 seconds remaining produced the final points, and his steal with 11 seconds to play sealed the semifinal upset.

Harvey, which was averaging 73 points per game, scored five points in the fourth quarter, none in the last four minutes, and committed turnovers on its final four possessions.

The Red Raiders (23-2) had a senior-laden team that lost in the 2005 and 2006 regional finals and entered this week with a 23-game winning streak.

"The pressure mounts every



JOSHUA GUNTER | THE PLAIN DEALER

The defense of Poland Seminary's Anthony DeFelice, right, knocks the ball away from Painesville Harvey's Scott Aston during the fourth quarter Thursday night.

level you move up, and every team here is a good team," Harvey coach Tim Starkey said. "We always play it one game at a time. We just didn't get it done."

"It's disappointing because of the goals we had and the fact that we had been down here before."

Harvey forward David Alston's 10 points led Harvey. He scored eight in the second quarter as the Red Raiders took a 25-22 halftime lead. Backup guard Wes Paramore scored eight points and center Jeff Spikes had six points and 10 rebounds. Point guard Scott Aston was held to five points and took four shots.

Guard Ben Umbel's 10 points led Poland, while Lovell and Anthony DeFelice each had nine. DeFelice's inside bucket with 1 minute remaining and his 3-pointer at the buzzer gave the Bulldogs a 37-36 lead at the end of the third quarter.

The Red Raiders, many of them sobbing in the locker room, struggled to come to grips with the defeat. "I feel we should have won that game," Aston said. "There's no way that team was better than us."

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BOYS REGIONAL SEMIFINAL

Sparks, Bulldogs end Cardinals' run

MIKE PETICCA
Plain Dealer Reporter

CANTON — Tyler Sparks has made a career of making a difference in big games. He did it again on Thursday night in the Fieldhouse.

"That's why Tyler is all-Ohio," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said after Sparks carried the Bulldogs to a 58-48 victory over Kenmore in a Division II regional semifinal game.

"That's why he should be a Division I college player. He's been doing that for us for a long time."

Sparks, a 6-4 guard-forward who will play basketball at Division II Findlay College, scored 19 points, grabbed 18 rebounds and dished six assists. Olmsted Falls (22-2) will play Upper Sandusky in a regional championship game on Saturday night at the University of Toledo.

Guard-forward Pat Pellerite and forward Kyle Bungard both scored 10 points for the Bulldogs, The Plain Dealer's fifth-ranked team.

Standout forward Joe Miller scored 14 points for Kenmore (17-7) before fouling out early in the fourth quarter, and point guard Marcus Golden tallied 10 points. The Cardinals, making their first regional appearance in more than 30 years, made just 8 of 21 free-throw attempts but kept the game close with their multiple defenses. Ken-

more held Olmsted Falls 20 points below its scoring average, after earning upset wins over 10th-ranked Buchtel (62-42) and seventh-ranked St. Vincent-St. Mary (54-52 in double overtime) in district games.

"It's been unbelievable," Kenmore coach Dan Freeman said. "Since we beat Buchtel, the kids in the hallways have been high-fiving each other and people everywhere have been saying 'Go Cards.' The support has been great. It's been fun, and I'm proud of the kids."

Kenmore cut a 10-point Bulldogs lead to 31-29 midway through the third quarter. Bungard then canned a 3-point shot, and the Bulldogs extended their lead to 39-31 on Sparks' 3-pointer from midcourt at the third quarter buzzer.

"It was lucky, that's for sure," Sparks said of the long trey. "It was a bit of a momentum-changer. Kenmore is a great team. This is a confidence-booster."

Sparks then made two passes on the fast break to up the Bulldogs lead to 43-31, first setting up two free throws by Alex Sedlay, and then feeding Dave Pellerite for a layup.

Olmsted Falls played solid man-to-man defense, a key for the Bulldogs since their 36 percent field-goal shooting was well below their norm.

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HIGH SCHOOL NEWSWATCH

Fund-raiser set for gymnast

A fund-raiser for Rachel Kayza, the Notre Dame-Cathedral Latin gymnast who was diagnosed with bacterial meningitis in February, will be held March 30 from 7 p.m. to midnight at Cappelli's Party Center, 7701 Reynolds Road, in Mentor.

The condition of Kayza, a 14-year-old freshman, is not known. She is being treated at Rainbow Babies and Children's Hospital in Cleveland.

Bacterial meningitis is an infection transmitted by saliva or sputum. Symptoms may include fever, headache, vomiting, stiff neck and rash. The disease can cause complications, including brain damage, kidney failure, blindness, coma, gangrene and limb damage, which can lead to

amputation. Tickets for the fund-raiser, which includes dinner, a cash bar, disc jockey, door prizes and two auctions, cost \$30 and can be purchased by calling Lisa Holley, 440-352-0368; or Theresa Jaros, 440-221-1426.

— Carl Matzelle

St. Ed, Olmsted Falls game times changed: Times for two boys basketball regional championship games on Saturday in Toledo have been changed. The Division I final between St. Edward and Findlay will be played at 3 p.m. The Division II final between Olmsted Falls and Upper Sandusky will be played at 7:30 p.m.

— From staff reports

HIGH SCHOOL SCOREBOARD

BOYS BASKETBALL

Regional semifinals

Thursday's scores

DIVISION I

Cin. St. Xavier 75, Trotwood-Madison 64

Cin. Withrow 58, Cin. Elder 57

Newark 51, Cols. Northland 45

DIVISION II

Chillicothe 51, Zanesville 49

Cols. DeSales 57, Dresden Td-Valley 47

Day, Dunbar 62, Tipp City Tippecanoe 53

Kettering Alter 76, Cols. Beechcroft 62

Upper Sandusky 79, Van Wert 62

DIVISION III

At University of Akron

Glenville 7 13 15 12-45

Firestone 17 8 1 15-48

Cleveland Glenville (17-8): Holt 2-4, Daniel 0-1, Gibson 1-4-8, Catney 1-0-3, Hines 0-3-19, Black 1-0-2, Smith 1-0-2, McCrison 1-0-4, Willis 1-0-2.

Alton Firestone (18-5): Mitchell 7-9-24, Phillips 1-0-2, Johnson 7-2-8, Jo. Pope 1-2-4, Jo. Pope 3-3-10.

DIVISION IV

At Canton Fieldhouse

Kenmore 8 10 13 37-48

Olmsted Falls 12 18 15 39-58

Alton Kenmore (16-6): Golden 3-4-10, Miller 7-0-14, Smith 2-1-5, Seligson 1-0-2, Hearn 0-3-19, Black 1-0-2, Higgins 1-0-2, Payne 3-2-6.

Olmsted Falls (22-2): Salazar 2-2-4, D. Pellerite 3-0-7, Sparks 6-0-9, Sedlay 1-2-4, R. Pellerite 4-1-10, Bungard 3-3-10, Kimmey 0-2-2.

DIVISION V

Harvey 14 11 11 54-41

Seminary 12 18 15 52-42

Harvey (22-3): Aston 2-0-5, Singleton 3-1-7, Alston 4-0-1, Johnson 0-2-2, Soler 2-2-6, Jackson 0-2-2, Pellerite 3-0-8.

Poland Seminary (23-2): Carcho 1-4-8, DeFelice 3-0-9, Lovell 3-0-9, Umbel 5-0-10, Capella 2-0-4.

Benedictine 11 19 13 9-52

Fairless 14 12 14 11-51

Benedictine (15-8): Dismuke 1-0-2, Boylston 2-1-6, Wright 2-4-9, Horn 1-0-2, Stothro 1-0-0, White 2-0-5.

Jackson 4-0-10, Woods 6-4-16

Fairless (17-8): Manack 4-2-14, Erb 1-0-2, Penland 2-1-5, Cross 1-0-2, Jennings 3-0-14, Baer 3-0-14.

REGIONAL CHAMPIONSHIP SCHEDULE

SATURDAY

DIVISION I

At University of Akron

GlenOak (23-3) vs. Alton Firestone (18-5), 7:30

At Xavier University

Cin. St. Xavier (29-9) vs. Cin. Withrow (17-5), 7:30

At Fairgrounds Coliseum, Columbus

Cin. McElroy (22-2) vs. Newark (24-1), 7:30

DIVISION II

At University of Toledo

Findlay (20-3) vs. St. Edward (24-0), 7:30

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

DIVISION III

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION IV

At Bowling Green State University

Liberty-Benton (24-0) vs. St. Henry (17-4), 7:30

At Canton Fieldhouse

Vila Angela-St. Joseph (17-7) vs. Lutheran West (22-1), 7:30

DIVISION V

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION VI

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION VII

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION VIII

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION IX

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION X

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION XI

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION XII

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.

DIVISION XIII

At Ohio University, Athens

Cols. DeSales (21-3) vs. Chillicothe (18-5), 3 p.m.

At Wright State University, Dayton

Kettering Alter (21-2) vs. Dayton Dunbar (21-4), 11 a.m.

At University of Toledo

Olmsted Falls (22-2) vs. Upper Sandusky (21-3), 7:30

At Memorial Civic Center, Canton

Poland Seminary (22-3) vs. Benedictine (15-8), 3 p.m.